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(FROM LEFT) ZARDARI, GILANI AND SHARIF NEED TO MEND FENCES URGENTLY BEFORE THE SITUATION SPINS OUT OF CONTROL

ZARDARI HAS BECOME INCREASINGLY ISOLATED AND his rift with the army has become serious. Despite the lack of political unity, the army may be loath to seize power again.

move. "We convinced them that our priority had to be those who posed the most immediate danger to Pakistan," explains the source. "That is the only way we could get public and local support. We have to take things one step at a time." Pakistan has also apparently asked the US not to interfere to avoid any impression that this was not a Pakistani operation, nor even to issue any statements of direct support.

Tactically, the army has moved towards the Mehsud area in a pincer movement from three directions and

blocked the strip of land separating the area from the Afghanistan border. It has also relied heavily this time on aerial bombardment to "soften up" their targets. This, as in the Swat operation before it, necessitated large-scale shifting of civilian populations, which has led to a new growing humanitarian crisis. Camps established in the town of Dera Ismail Khan, bordering the area, have seen a steady influx of poor, bedraggled families, many of whom have fled with nothing more than the clothes on their backs.

Although the numbers of the internally displaced persons are nowhere near the magnitude seen earlier from the Malakand region—the estimate for the displaced is about two lakh—the remoteness of the region and the military's choking off of exit points before the launch of the operation, has meant there are many horror stories of families forced to travel by foot over rocky terrain to escape the bombing.

However, the "national consensus" over the operation has largely inured the military so far to the humanitarian